Acta Psychologica Sinica
2026, Vol. 58, No. 12, 1–24
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https://doi.org/10.3724/SP.J.1041.2026.00000

The purse and the cradle: The effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions

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Abstract

Persistently declining fertility poses a major social challenge in many countries. Drawing on a socioecological psychological perspective, this research examined the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions and the psychological processes underlying it. Four studies comprising five component studies combined large-scale social media analysis (Study 1), data from the China Family Panel Studies (Study 2), a questionnaire survey (Study 3), and experiments with Chinese (Study 4A) and U.S. (Study 4B) participants. Across studies, greater perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions; the experiments provided evidence for a causal effect of the inequality manipulation. Financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress each showed significant indirect effects when examined separately. In parallel mediation models, only the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress remained significant, making it the more consistently supported pathway. These findings suggest that perceived economic inequality may discourage childbearing through anxiety about maintaining one's own financial status (the intragenerational status-maintenance pathway) and anticipated demands associated with raising children (the intergenerational responsibility-anticipation pathway). By linking perceptions of macroeconomic conditions to individual psychological processes, the findings offer a socioecological account of low fertility intentions and suggest implications for fertility-support policies.

Keywords perceived economic inequality, fertility intentions, anticipated parenting stress, financial status anxiety

1 Introduction

Persistently declining fertility has become one of the most pressing demographic and socioeconomic challenges of the 21st century. According to the United Nations, the global total fertility rate declined from 4.8 in 1970 to 2.3 in 2024, and more than half of economies worldwide are now experiencing low fertility, with the trend being particularly pronounced in East Asia (United Nations, 2025). China provides a salient example. In 2025, the number of births nationwide fell to only 7.92 million, and the natural population growth rate declined to −2.41‰ (National Bureau of Statistics of China, 2026). A substantial body of research has shown that weakening fertility intentions are closely associated with declines in actual fertility (e.g., Balbo et al., 2013). Identifying the factors that shape fertility intentions is therefore important for understanding the mechanisms underlying contemporary low fertility.

Previous research has identified a range of determinants of fertility intentions at multiple levels, including individual-level economic circumstances and employment stability, family-level childrearing costs and intergenerational support, and policy-level fertility incentives (Li et al., 2019; Yu et al., 2021; Brea-Martínez & Dribe, 2025; Lan et al., 2025). Collectively, these findings underscore the importance of material resources and external support in reproductive decision-making. Yet a puzzling pattern remains. Despite sustained economic growth and the progressive relaxation of fertility restrictions in China, fertility rates have not rebounded as expected but have instead continued to decline. This apparent contradiction suggests that fertility intentions may be shaped not only by the absolute level of objective material resources, but also by how individuals subjectively perceive their material circumstances.

Against the backdrop of economic growth, rising economic inequality has become an increasingly salient feature of contemporary societies (Gastwirth & Zhao, 2025). Unlike overall levels of economic development, economic inequality refers to the extent to which resources are unevenly distributed within a society (Willis et al., 2022). This distinction offers an important comparative perspective for understanding fertility intentions. Relative to absolute income, individuals' perceptions of the gap between the rich and the poor may shape how they evaluate their own economic position and future life prospects, thereby influencing reproductive decision-making. Highly unequal environments may intensify social comparison and heighten a sense of relative disadvantage. Thus, even when individuals' objective economic circumstances are reasonably favorable, they may still perceive childbearing as a high-risk and high-cost undertaking.

However, existing research has yet to systematically examine, from a socioecological psychological perspective, whether

Received Date: January 27, 2026

* This research was supported by the Ministry of Education Humanities and Social Sciences Research Planning Fund (24YJA190015) and the Fujian Provincial Social Science Fund (FJ2025C066).

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The original article is in Chinese. The Chinese version shall always prevail in case of any discrepancy or inconsistency between the Chinese version and its English translation.

and how perceived economic inequality is associated with fertility intentions and through which psychological processes this association may operate. Importantly, delays and declines in first births are a major contributor to the overall decline in fertility; reductions in first births may, in turn, further constrain second- and third-birth rates, creating a cumulative downward cycle (He, 2023). Accordingly, the present research focuses primarily on childless adults of reproductive age and examines whether perceived economic inequality predicts fertility intentions, as well as the psychological mechanisms through which this effect may emerge. By integrating macro-level socioeconomic conditions with micro-level psychological processes, this research aims to provide a socioecological psychological account of the contemporary low-fertility phenomenon.

1.1 Perceived Economic Inequality and Fertility Intentions

The widening gap between the rich and the poor has become an increasingly urgent social issue attracting attention from governments, scholars, and the public worldwide (Gastwirth & Zhao, 2025). As a major life-course decision, childbearing is deeply embedded in the socioeconomic environment in which individuals live, and its relationship with macro-level patterns of economic distribution has received growing scholarly attention. Research in economics and demography has primarily examined the relationship between objective economic inequality and fertility rates or fertility intentions, yet the findings remain inconsistent. For example, using data from the 2014 and 2018 waves of the China Family Panel Studies (CFPS), Wang et al. (2024) found that greater regional income inequality significantly reduced individuals' fertility intentions. In contrast, Li et al. (2024), using the 2018 CFPS data and constructing a relative deprivation index based on household per capita net income as an indicator of income inequality, found that greater income inequality was associated with stronger fertility intentions. Although these studies provide valuable insights into the relationship between economic inequality and fertility intentions, their divergent findings also suggest that the association between objective economic inequality and fertility intentions is not robust and may vary depending on the indicators used and the level of analysis. Thus, objective indicators of income or wealth inequality alone may be insufficient to fully explain the complex processes underlying individual fertility decisions.

More importantly, findings concerning objective economic inequality cannot be directly equated with or generalized to subjective perceptions of economic inequality. Objective indicators capture the actual distribution of socioeconomic resources, whereas whether individuals perceive inequality and incorporate such perceptions into their fertility decisions depends on complex cognitive and evaluative processes (Phillips et al., 2026). Consequently, even when individuals are exposed to the same objective level of inequality, they may differ substantially in how strongly they perceive the gap between the rich and the poor, how they cognitively evaluate it, and how they emotionally respond to it (Willis et al., 2022). These subjective experiences may constitute the more proximal psychological drivers of fertility intentions. However, existing research has relied predominantly on inequality measures constructed from income or wealth data, with relatively little attention to individuals' subjective perceptions of economic inequality. Even fewer studies have experimentally manipulated perceived inequality to establish causal relationships. Accordingly, the present research focuses on perceived economic inequality and examines its effects on fertility intentions and the psychological mechanisms underlying these effects.

We propose that perceived economic inequality may reduce fertility intentions primarily by altering individuals' allocation of resources and their expectations regarding the costs of childbearing. First, according to time allocation theory, individuals have finite amounts of time and energy and must allocate these resources across market work, household production—including childbearing and childrearing—and leisure activities (Becker, 1965). When high economic inequality creates a social environment characterized by intense competition for resources, individuals may allocate a greater share of their resources to market activities that can directly generate economic returns and enhance social status. Prior research has shown that economic inequality is associated with longer working hours and greater work–family conflict (Filippi et al., 2023; Liu et al., 2026). Thus, greater perceived economic inequality may systematically crowd out the time, energy, and other resources available for family formation and childrearing, thereby weakening the material and psychological foundations of childbearing.

Second, the competitive environment fostered by perceived inequality may also increase individuals' perceived costs of having children. In a social climate characterized by intense competition and comparison, raising children may no longer be viewed merely as a matter of biological reproduction, but increasingly as an investment competition centered on "positional goods" (Hirsch, 1976). To ensure that their children do not "fall behind at the starting line," parents may feel compelled to make substantial investments in high-quality education, housing in desirable school districts, extracurricular training, and other resources—a pattern consistent with intensive parenting (Doepke & Zilibotti, 2019). Under such conditions, childbearing may be perceived as a high-risk undertaking requiring substantial financial and emotional investment. These heightened expectations regarding the costs and risks of childrearing may directly suppress fertility intentions.

Taken together, perceived economic inequality may create a social-cognitive environment characterized by competition, resource scarcity, and uncertainty about the future, thereby reducing individuals' fertility intentions. Accordingly, we propose the following hypothesis:

Hypothesis 1: Perceived economic inequality will reduce individuals' fertility intentions.

However, the specific psychological processes underlying this relationship remain unclear. How does perceived economic inequality translate into individual decisions to avoid or postpone childbearing? We propose that this effect may operate primarily through two pathways: an intragenerational pathway, involving anxiety about maintaining one's own socioeconomic position, and an intergenerational pathway, involving anticipated responsibilities for securing children's future development. We elaborate on these two pathways below.

1.2 The Intragenerational Status-Maintenance Pathway: The Mediating Role of Financial Status Anxiety

To explain how perceived economic inequality may undermine fertility intentions, we first introduce financial status anxiety as a key psychological mechanism. Financial status anxiety refers to feelings of insecurity, concern, and dissatisfaction regarding one's wealth and social status (Melita et al., 2021). According to social comparison theory, individuals often

evaluate their abilities and social standing through comparisons with others (Festinger, 1954). Greater economic inequality raises the reference standard for what constitutes "success" and a "decent life," making social comparisons both more frequent and more threatening. In the financial domain, individuals tend to engage more readily in upward than downward comparisons (Boyce et al., 2010), making them particularly susceptible to feelings of relative disadvantage. Previous research has shown that even after controlling for objective income, individuals living in more unequal environments are more likely to perceive their income as "low" or "insufficient" (Sánchez-Rodríguez et al., 2019). This suggests that perceived economic inequality may amplify experiences of relative disadvantage through social comparison. Over time, such persistent feelings of disadvantage may develop into chronic concerns and insecurity about one's financial standing—that is, financial status anxiety (Melita et al., 2021).

This process can also be understood from the perspective of social identity theory. In highly unequal societies, financial status becomes a particularly salient basis of social categorization, leading individuals to perceive and differentiate social groups more strongly along economic lines (Peters et al., 2022). As wealth disparities become increasingly salient, the social meanings and evaluations attached to different income groups also become more differentiated, with higher-income groups often being associated with more favorable social images and greater social value. Under such conditions, individuals' self-esteem and sense of self-worth may become increasingly contingent on their relative economic position (Cheng, Hao, et al., 2026; Park et al., 2021). As a result, any threat of downward mobility or blocked upward mobility may be experienced as a threat to the self, thereby generating persistent financial status anxiety. Empirical evidence supports this account: Individuals who perceive greater economic inequality report higher levels of insecurity and anxiety concerning their own social status (Mao et al., 2026; Melita et al., 2021).

Concerns about one's financial standing may, in turn, shape how individuals prioritize competing life goals. To alleviate such concerns, individuals may devote more time and resources to maintaining or improving their current financial status (van Vugt et al., 2026). For example, individuals living in more economically unequal regions tend to work longer hours (Liu et al., 2026). Prioritizing wealth accumulation and status competition in this way necessarily reduces the time, energy, and financial resources available for marriage and childbearing, potentially leading individuals to postpone having children or to prefer fewer children (Kaplan et al., 2015).

Taken together, perceived economic inequality may heighten financial status anxiety, prompting individuals to prioritize resources toward coping with status competition and, consequently, reducing their fertility intentions. We therefore propose:

Hypothesis 2: Perceived economic inequality will reduce fertility intentions by increasing financial status anxiety.

1.3 The Intergenerational Responsibility-Anticipation Pathway: The Mediating Role of Anticipated Parenting Stress

In addition to heightening anxiety about one's own status, perceived economic inequality may reduce fertility intentions by altering individuals' expectations regarding the future demands of parenting. In the present research, anticipated parenting stress refers to individuals' subjective expectations, prior to having children, regarding the financial resources and effort that would be required to raise and educate a child, as well as the psychological burden associated with these anticipated demands (Huang et al., 2023). Such stress may be particularly salient in highly unequal social environments.

On the one hand, greater economic inequality is often associated with a perceived hardening of the opportunity structure, whereby individuals perceive fewer opportunities for upward mobility among the next generation and a greater risk of downward mobility (Schechtl, 2025). Such perceptions of unequal opportunity and future uncertainty may directly undermine individuals' sense of security regarding their children's future socioeconomic prospects (Ma et al., 2025). From a status-decline avoidance perspective, individuals tend to become more risk averse when confronted with the possibility of loss and may therefore hope that their children will attain at least the same, if not a higher, social position than their own (Kahneman & Tversky, 1979). Consequently, even before having children, individuals may anticipate that substantial investments in parenting will be necessary to prevent their future children from "falling down the social ladder." This expectation may generate a strong perception that successful parenting will require exceptionally intensive investment.

On the other hand, economic inequality may also strengthen the role of educational attainment and occupational success as mechanisms of social stratification, making them increasingly important forms of capital for maintaining or improving family status (Bourdieu, 1986). In this context, parents may be more likely to internalize high educational achievement—for example, admission to elite schools and access to prestigious occupations—as a central criterion of "successful parenting." Such standards may substantially increase their expectations regarding the time, money, and emotional resources required for future childrearing. Existing research suggests that when individuals perceive greater economic inequality, parents tend to hold higher achievement expectations for their children and are more likely to engage in high-investment, intensive parenting practices (Lubiewska et al., 2025; Zhang et al., 2025). This combination of fearing downward mobility while simultaneously aspiring to upward mobility for one's children may substantially heighten anticipated parenting stress even before childbearing occurs.

Greater anticipated parenting stress may, in turn, directly reduce fertility intentions. According to subjective expected utility theory, fertility decisions are not determined solely by objective calculations of available resources but are also shaped by individuals' subjective expectations and psychological evaluations (Edwards, 1954; Hoffman et al., 1978). When anticipated parenting stress is high, it may enter the decision-making process as a substantial psychological cost, thereby reducing the subjective expected utility of having children. Previous research has shown that greater perceived parenting stress is associated with a greater likelihood of postponing or forgoing childbearing (Huang et al., 2023; Zhao et al., 2024). In addition, excessively high expectations of future parenting demands may undermine individuals' perceived control over future family life and consume psychological resources that might otherwise be devoted to career development and self-realization, thereby further reducing the emotional appeal of childbearing (Becker, 1965).

In sum, perceived economic inequality may heighten anticipated parenting stress by amplifying concerns about children's downward mobility and expectations regarding successful childrearing, thereby creating a prospective psychological burden that discourages fertility. Accordingly, we propose:

Hypothesis 3: Perceived economic inequality will reduce fertility intentions by increasing anticipated parenting stress.

The theoretical model is shown in Figure 1.

2 Study 1 (Social Media Data Analysis): The Relationship Between Perceived Economic Inequality and Fertility Intentions

To test Hypothesis 1 in a real-world context with high ecological validity and to capture how the proposed model is reflected in the public's everyday expressions, Study 1 conducted a large-scale observational analysis of social media data. The final dataset included 412,580 relevant posts from 311,528 users. We applied latent semantic analysis (LSA) to quantify the extent to which each post reflected perceived economic inequality and low fertility intentions. Specifically, we calculated the semantic similarity between each post and dictionary vectors representing the target constructs—perceived economic inequality and low fertility intentions. This approach allowed us to empirically examine the proposed theoretical relationship in naturally occurring social discourse.

2.1 Method

2.1.1 Data Collection

Sina Weibo is one of the most influential social media platforms and major venues for public discourse in China (Chen, 2024). Using three highly discussed fertility-related topics—"#fertility," "#having children," and "#do not want children"—as search terms, we collected posts published between May 31, 2021, and December 3, 2025, using an open-source web crawler. A total of 484,828 raw posts were obtained.

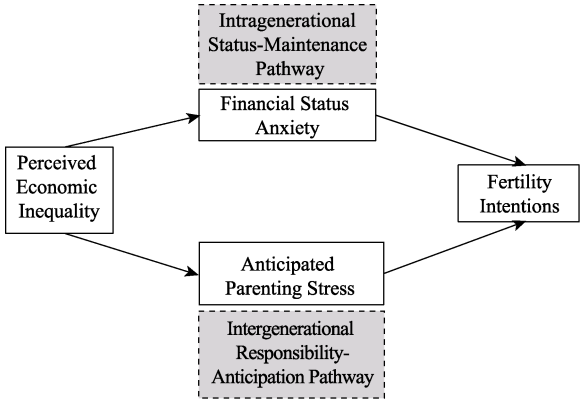


Figure 1. Theoretical model

First, completely duplicated posts were removed using the duplicate-identification function in Microsoft Excel. The remaining posts were then manually reviewed one by one according to prespecified screening criteria. Specifically, we (1) excluded posts unrelated to marriage or fertility, such as promotional or marketing content; (2) excluded posts containing only emojis, images, or hyperlinks without substantive textual content; and (3) excluded reposts that contained only repost markers (e.g., "//@username") without any original commentary. For reposts that included original user-generated text, only the user's original commentary was retained, whereas the reposted source content was removed to prevent duplicated information from influencing the semantic analyses.

A total of 72,248 invalid posts were removed during data cleaning, resulting in a final sample of 412,580 valid posts from 311,528 users.

2.1.2 Measures

Consistent with prior research (Pan et al., 2024), we used latent semantic analysis (LSA), a natural language processing technique, to capture the constructs of interest. Figure 2 illustrates the LSA procedure.

The collected posts were first preprocessed by (a) extracting Chinese characters, (b) converting traditional Chinese characters to simplified Chinese, and (c) conducting word segmentation and stop-word removal using the tmcn and jieba packages in R. For each preprocessed post, text vectorization and dimensionality reduction were conducted in Python 3.14.0 using the scikit-learn library. Specifically, the posts and construct dictionaries were first transformed into term frequency–inverse document frequency (TF-IDF) vectors using TfidfVectorizer. Dimensionality reduction was then performed using TruncatedSVD with 100 latent dimensions (k = 100) and a random seed of 42. Finally, cosine similarity was calculated between each post and the corresponding construct dictionary in the latent semantic space.Cosine similarity scores ranged from −1 to 1, with higher values indicating greater semantic similarity between a post and the corresponding construct dictionary. On this basis, we quantified the extent to which each post expressed perceived economic inequality (M = 0.02, SD = 0.09) and low fertility intentions (M = 0.05, SD = 0.09).

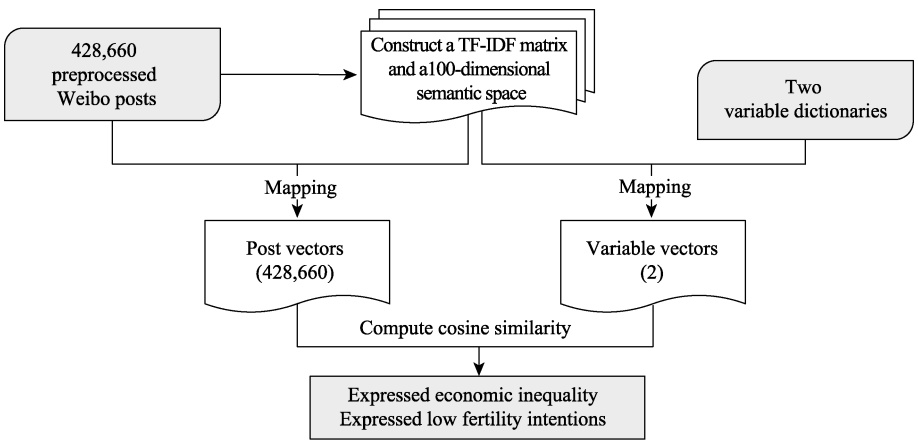


Figure 2. Illustration of the Latent Semantic Analysis Procedure

Based on established definitions of economic inequality (Schmalor & Heine, 2022) and fertility intentions (Chen et al., 2024), as well as common expressions used in Chinese social media contexts, we constructed two dictionaries: an economic inequality dictionary containing 8 terms and a low fertility intentions dictionary containing 26 terms (see Table 1).To assess dictionary validity, 300 posts were randomly selected and independently rated by two trained raters according to a standardized coding manual (see Online Supplementary Appendix 2). Prior to formal coding, both raters received standardized training and independently coded five practice posts, followed by discussion to ensure a shared understanding of the coding criteria.Interrater reliability was assessed using intraclass correlation coefficients (ICCs) based on a two-way random-effects, absolute-agreement model. The results showed high agreement between the two raters for both perceived economic inequality, ICC = 0.92, 95% CI [0.90, 0.93], $p < 0.001$, and low fertility intentions, ICC = 0.93, 95% CI [0.91, 0.94], $p < 0.001$. Both ICC values exceeded .90 (Koo & Li, 2016), indicating excellent interrater reliability.

We then compared the mean standardized human ratings provided by the two raters with the automated LSA-based dictionary scores. The resulting consistency reliabilities, corrected using the Spearman–Brown formula, were $\alpha = 0.68$ for the perceived economic inequality dictionary and $\alpha = 0.64$ for the low fertility intentions dictionary.

2.2 Results

We fitted a linear mixed-effects model (LMM) in Python 3.14.0. The low fertility intentions score served as the dependent variable, and the perceived economic inequality score was entered as the focal predictor. To obtain a more accurate estimate of the association between the two variables, the model included several fixed-effect covariates. Year and month were included to account for macro-level temporal trends and seasonal fluctuations, such as the potential influence of the COVID-19 pandemic and fertility-related policy changes on public discussion. Post length, measured as the number of words in each post, was also included to account for possible effects of text length on semantic similarity scores. In addition, a random intercept for user was specified to account for the nonindependence of multiple posts contributed by the same user (Dehghani et al., 2016; Kim et al., 2022). The user-level intraclass correlation coefficient was .045, indicating that approximately 4.5% of the variance in low fertility intentions scores was attributable to between-user differences. This finding further supported the inclusion of a user-level random intercept.

The results supported Hypothesis 1. Across posts, expressed perceived economic inequality was significantly and positively associated with expressed low fertility intentions, $b = 0.11$, $SE = 0.002$, $p < 0.001$. Thus, after controlling for temporal trends, seasonal variation, and text characteristics, posts expressing stronger perceived economic inequality also tended to express stronger low fertility intentions.

2.3 Discussion

Using naturally occurring social media text, Study 1 provided initial evidence for an association between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions in public discourse. After controlling for temporal trends, seasonal fluctuations, and post length, posts expressing stronger perceived economic inequality also contained stronger expressions of low fertility intentions, providing preliminary support for Hypothesis 1. These findings suggest that economic inequality is not merely a macrostructural feature of society; it is also reflected in individuals' everyday discourse and is closely associated with how they express attitudes toward childbearing. The predictive effect of perceived economic inequality on low fertility intentions was modest in magnitude ($b = 0.11$), which is consistent with the naturally occurring, unstructured, and highly context-dependent nature of social media text. Because such text contains substantial variability and semantic noise, automated semantic analysis may face greater uncertainty when inferring latent psychological states (Khan et al., 2025). Moreover, fertility intentions are shaped by a wide range of factors, including social norms, partner relationships, and caregiving support (Brea-Martínez & Dribe, 2025; Lan et al., 2025). Thus, even relatively small effects of a single predictor may still be theoretically and practically meaningful when observed across large samples and at the population level (Funder & Ozer, 2019; Götz et al., 2022). Nevertheless, Study 1 relied on an observational design and therefore did not permit causal inference. In addition, although LSA-based semantic analysis is useful for capturing naturally occurring trends in public expression, it is less precise than standardized questionnaire measures and does not allow comprehensive control of individual-level demographic characteristics. Accordingly, Study 2 used nationally representative data from the China Family Panel Studies (CFPS) to further examine the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions.

3 Study 2 (Nationally Representative Survey): Replication of the Relationship Between Perceived Economic Inequality and Fertility Intentions

Study 2 used more structured individual-level measures to further examine the relationship identified in Study 1 in a nationally representative sample. Whereas Study 1 focused on naturally occurring expressions of public attitudes, Study 2 drew on data from the 2022 China Family Panel Studies (CFPS; data source: Institute of Social Science Survey, Peking University, http://www.isss.pku.edu.cn/cfps/) to reexamine the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions. The CFPS is a nationally representative longitudinal survey with broad academic influence. The 2022 sample covered 25 provinces, municipalities, and autonomous regions and represented approximately 95% of the Chinese population. By examining the association between individuals' subjective perceptions of economic inequality and their fertility intentions,

Table 1
Variable Dictionaries

Construct	Dictionary terms	Reliability (α)
Perceived economic inequality	wealth gap, polarization, income gap, extreme wealth disparity, poor people, rich people, lower class, wealthy people (8 terms in total)	0.68
Low fertility intentions	do not have children, do not want to have children, will not have children, do not give birth, do not want children, DINK, cannot afford to have children, cannot afford to raise children, do not plan to have children, and related expressions (26 terms in total)	0.64

Study 2 aimed to provide more generalizable evidence for the relationship between these two variables.

3.1 Method

3.1.1 Participants

Data were drawn from the 2022 CFPS, which included an original sample of 27,001 participants. There were 19,988 missing responses on the focal variable of perceived income inequality (74.0% missing) and 3,679 missing responses on ideal number of children (13.6% missing). To ensure the quality of the focal variables, participants with missing responses on either of these variables—including responses coded as "not applicable," "refuse to answer," or "do not know"—were excluded. Missing values on the control variables were handled using multiple imputation. Twenty imputed datasets were generated, and estimates were pooled according to Rubin's rules. The final analytic sample consisted of 6,982 participants, including 3,435 women, with a mean age of 45.27 years (SD = 16.55).

3.1.2 Measures

Perceived economic inequality. Perceived economic inequality was measured with a single item: "Overall, how serious do you think the gap between the rich and the poor is in China?" Participants responded on a scale ranging from 0 (*not serious at all*) to 10 (*very serious*), with higher scores indicating greater perceived economic inequality.

Fertility intentions. Ideal number of children was used as an indicator of fertility intentions. The 2022 CFPS asked, "How many children do you think would be ideal?" Participants could report a value ranging from 0 to 10, with higher values indicating stronger fertility intentions.

Control variables. Age, gender, educational attainment, income level, and hukou type were included as control variables.

3.2 Results

3.2.1 Descriptive Statistics and Correlational Analyses

Because the dependent variable was discrete count data and did not satisfy the assumption of normality, we conducted nonparametric Spearman rank-order correlation analyses. As shown in Table 2, perceived economic inequality was negatively correlated with fertility intentions, $r = -0.20$, $p < 0.001$. Thus, the greater the economic inequality participants perceived, the fewer children they considered ideal.

3.2.2 Relationship Between Perceived Economic Inequality and Fertility Intentions

Because the dependent variable, ideal number of children, was a count variable, we first examined its dispersion characteristics. The variance-to-mean ratio was 0.42, indicating substantial underdispersion. Because conventional Poisson regression does not adequately accommodate underdispersed count data, we used Conway–Maxwell–Poisson (COM-Poisson) regression, implemented with the COMPoissonReg package in R (Sellers & Lotze, 2023). By incorporating a dispersion parameter, ν, the COM-Poisson model can flexibly accommodate count data exhibiting different degrees of dispersion.

The model demonstrated good fit, with a log-likelihood of −8430.40, AIC = 16878.80, and BIC = 16940.40. The estimated dispersion parameter was $\nu = 3.25$[1], which was substantially greater than 1, indicating that the model appropriately captured the underdispersion in the data.

As shown in Table 3, perceived economic inequality remained a significant negative predictor of fertility intentions after controlling for age, gender, educational attainment, hukou type, and income level, $b = -0.03$, $SE = 0.002$, $z = -14.51$, $p < 0.001$. Specifically, holding all other variables constant, each one-unit increase in perceived economic inequality was associated with an approximately 3% decrease in the expected ideal number of children (IRR = 0.97, 95% CI [0.96, 0.97]). Thus, greater perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions.

3.3 Discussion

Using nationally representative survey data, Study 2 replicated the negative relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions, providing further support for Hypothesis 1. However, because of limitations in the measures available in the CFPS, both perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions were assessed with single-item measures, which may have limited their reliability and validity. In addition, the missing-data analysis indicated that individuals with lower levels of education were more likely to have missing responses on the focal variables. Such patterns of missingness are relatively common in large-scale national surveys. Individuals with lower levels of education may be more likely to select responses such as "do not know" or "refuse to answer" when responding to abstract questions or sensitive items involving personal attitudes and values, because of greater comprehension difficulties or concerns about responding (Tan, 2024; Wiessner et al., 2025). To address these limitations, Study 3 used standardized multi-item questionnaires to improve measurement precision and validity and further examined the psychological mechanisms through which perceived economic inequality may reduce fertility intentions.

4 Study 3 (Questionnaire Survey): The Mediating Roles of Financial Status Anxiety and Anticipated Parenting Stress

To further investigate the psychological pathways through which perceived economic inequality influences fertility intentions, Study 3 used a questionnaire survey to examine their relationship and the potential mediating mechanisms. Specifically, this study aimed to (1) replicate the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions while controlling for relevant covariates and (2) examine the mediating roles of financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, thereby elucidating the psychological mechanisms through which perceived economic inequality may shape fertility-related decisions.

4.1 Method

4.1.1 Participants

Following da Silva Frost and Ledgerwood's (2020) recommendation that correlational studies should include at least 250 participants, we recruited 295 childless adults aged 18–35 through the Credamo platform. Seven participants who failed the attention check were excluded, resulting in a final sample of 288 participants, including 197 women. The mean age of the sample was 26.63 years (SD = 3.28).

4.1.2 Measures

Perceived economic inequality. Perceived economic inequality was assessed using the Individual Subjective Inequality

[1] The dispersion parameter ν characterizes the dispersion of the count distribution. Values of $\nu > 1$ indicate underdispersion, such that the variance is smaller than the mean and the distribution is more concentrated, whereas values of $\nu < 1$ indicate overdispersion, such that the variance is larger than the mean and the distribution is more dispersed.

Table 2
Descriptive Statistics and Correlations Among Variables in Study 2 (N = 6,982)

Variable	*M*	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
1. Perceived economic inequality	6.83	2.45	1						
2. Ideal number of children	1.86	0.88	−0.20***	1					
3. Income level	2.90	1.05	−0.15***	0.10***	1				
4. Educational attainment	5.07	1.86	0.04**	−0.05***	0.01	1			
5. Hukou type	2.41	2.33	0.09***	−0.02	−0.07***	−0.04***	1		
6. Age	45.27	16.55	−0.08***	0.29***	0.09***	−0.02*	−0.08***	1	
7. Gender	0.51	0.50	0.08***	0.01	0.04***	−0.01	−0.01	0.02	1

Note. * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Table 3
COM-Poisson Regression Predicting Fertility Intentions in Study 2 (N = 6,982)

Variable	fertility intention		
	b (*SE*)	*z*	IRR [95% CI]
Intercept	0.37 (0.03)***	11.40	1.45 [1.36, 1.54]
Perceived economic inequality	−0.03 (0.002)***	−14.51	0.97 [0.96, 0.97]
Personal income level	0.03 (0.01)***	5.08	1.03 [1.02, 1.04]
Educational attainment	−0.01 (0.003)	−1.82	1.00 [0.99, 1.00]
Hukou type	0.01 (0.002)**	3.16	1.01 [1.00, 1.01]
Age	0.007 (0.0003)***	21.38	1.01 [1.01, 1.01]
Gender	0.01 (0.01)	1.29	1.01 [0.99, 1.04]

Note. IRR = incidence rate ratio. To prevent some SE values from appearing as 0 after rounding, three or four decimal places are retained where necessary.

subscale of the Subjective Inequality Scale (SIS; Schmalor & Heine, 2022). The subscale consists of four items, such as "Most of the wealth in society goes to a small number of people" and "Real opportunities for success in life are available only to the rich." Participants rated each item on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), with higher scores indicating greater perceived economic inequality. The scale demonstrated good internal consistency in the present study (Cronbach's α = .86).

Fertility intentions. Fertility intentions were assessed using the six-item subscale for childless individuals from the Fertility Intention Scale developed by Chen et al. (2024). Sample items included "Having children is part of my life plan" and "Looking toward the future, I hope to become a father/mother." Participants rated each item on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), with higher scores indicating stronger fertility intentions. Internal consistency was excellent (Cronbach's α = 0.98).

Financial status anxiety. Financial status anxiety was assessed using an adapted version of the status anxiety scale developed by Melita et al. (2020). The scale contained five items, including "I worry that my current financial situation is poor" and "I am very concerned that I may have difficulty achieving my desired financial goals." Participants responded on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), with higher scores indicating greater financial status anxiety. Internal consistency was excellent (Cronbach's α = 0.92).

Anticipated parenting stress. Anticipated parenting stress was assessed using a self-developed eight-item questionnaire comprising two dimensions: anticipated financial stress and anticipated effort-related stress, with four items for each dimension. Sample items included "I worry that I may have difficulty affording the various expenses associated with raising a child in the future (e.g., education, medical care, and recreation)" and "To provide high-quality companionship and support for my child's development, I may need to reduce or give up some of my work or personal interests." Participants rated each item on a 7-point scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 7 (*strongly agree*), with higher scores indicating greater anticipated parenting stress. The total scale demonstrated excellent internal consistency (Cronbach's α = 0.94). Cronbach's α values for anticipated financial stress and anticipated effort-related stress were .94 and .87, respectively. Confirmatory factor analysis indicated that the two-factor model fit the data well, $\chi^2(19) = 38.06$, $p = 0.006$, RMSEA = 0.06, CFI = 0.99, TLI = 0.99, SRMR = 0.02. Standardized factor loadings ranged from 0.60 to 0.92. Model comparison further showed that the two-factor model fit the data significantly better than the one-factor model, $\Delta\chi^2(1) = 138.15$, $p < 0.001$, supporting the proposed two-dimensional structure of the scale.

Control variables. Gender, age, educational attainment, income level, and subjective socioeconomic status were included as control variables in subsequent analyses.

4.2 Results

4.2.1 Test of Common Method Bias

Confirmatory factor analyses were conducted in AMOS 29.0 to assess the potential influence of common method bias by comparing a one-factor model, in which all measurement items loaded onto a single latent factor, with a four-factor model consisting of fertility intentions, anticipated parenting stress, financial status anxiety, and perceived economic inequality. The

four-factor model, χ^2 = 584.99, *df* = 224, χ^2/df = 2.61, CFI = 0.946, TLI = 0.939, RMSEA = 0.075, SRMR = 0.063, fit the data substantially better than the one-factor model, χ^2 = 3626.97, *df* = 230, χ^2/df = 15.77, CFI = 0.493, TLI = 0.442, RMSEA = 0.227, SRMR = 0.171. The difference between the two models was statistically significant, $\Delta\chi^2$ = 3041.98, Δdf = 6, $p < 0.001$. These results suggested that common method bias was unlikely to pose a serious concern in the present study.

4.2.2 Descriptive Statistics and Correlational Analyses

Descriptive statistics and correlational analyses were conducted using SPSS 26.0. As shown in Table 4, perceived economic inequality was significantly negatively correlated with fertility intentions, $r = -0.23$, $p < 0.001$, and significantly positively correlated with both financial status anxiety, $r = 0.47$, $p < 0.001$, and anticipated parenting stress, $r = 0.45$, $p < 0.001$. In addition, financial status anxiety was significantly negatively correlated with fertility intentions, $r = -0.29$, $p < 0.001$, and anticipated parenting stress was likewise significantly negatively correlated with fertility intentions, $r = -0.49$, $p < 0.001$.

4.2.3 Relationship Between Perceived Economic Inequality and Fertility Intentions

To test Hypothesis 1, we conducted a hierarchical regression analysis while controlling for participants' age, gender, educational attainment, income level, and subjective socioeconomic status (see Table 5). Model 1 included only the control variables, whereas Model 2 additionally included perceived economic inequality. The results showed that perceived economic inequality significantly and negatively predicted fertility intentions, $\beta = -0.20$, $t = -3.31$, $p = 0.001$, $\Delta R^2 = 0.04$, providing further support for Hypothesis 1.

4.2.4 Mediating Roles of Financial Status Anxiety and Anticipated Parenting Stress

To test Hypotheses 2 and 3, mediation analyses were conducted using the PROCESS macro developed by Hayes (2013; Model 4) with 5,000 bootstrap samples. Age, gender, educational attainment, income level, and subjective socioeconomic status were included as covariates.

First, we examined the mediating role of financial status anxiety. As shown in Figure 3, the indirect effect through financial status anxiety was significant, $b = -0.04$, $SE = 0.01$, 95% CI [−0.07, −0.02]. Thus, greater perceived economic inequality was associated with higher financial status anxiety, which in turn was associated with lower fertility intentions.

Next, we examined the mediating role of anticipated parenting stress. As shown in Figure 4, the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was significant, $b = -0.08$, $SE = 0.01$, 95% CI [−0.10, −0.05]. Thus, greater perceived economic inequality was associated with greater anticipated parenting stress, which in turn was associated with lower fertility intentions.

Finally, to compare the relative contributions of financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, we tested a parallel mediation model in which both mediators were entered simultaneously. As shown in Figure 5, the direct effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions was not significant, $b = -0.01$, $SE = 0.02$, 95% CI [−0.06, 0.04]. The indirect effect through financial status anxiety was also not significant, $b = 0.02$, 95% CI [−0.01, 0.06], whereas the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress remained significant, $b = -0.09$, 95% CI [−0.13, −0.06]. These findings indicate that, when the two psychological pathways were considered simultaneously, anticipated parenting stress emerged as the more important mechanism linking perceived economic inequality to fertility intentions.

Table 4
Descriptive Statistics and Correlations in Study 3 (N = 288)

Variable	*M*	*SD*	1	2	3	4
1. Perceived economic inequality	4.91	1.27	1			
2. Financial status anxiety	4.98	1.45	0.47***	1		
3. Anticipated parenting stress	5.42	1.34	0.45***	0.73***	1	
4. Fertility intentions	4.33	1.95	−0.23***	−0.29***	−0.49***	1

Note. ***p < 0.001, two-tailed.

Table 5
Hierarchical Regression Predicting Fertility Intentions in Study 3 (N = 288)

Variables	Model 1		Model 2	
	Standardized β	Significance *p*	Standardized β	Significance *p*
Gender	−0.20	0.001	−0.18	0.003
Age	0.04	0.525	0.04	0.503
Education level	−0.07	0.260	−0.03	0.583
Income level	0.02	0.766	0.00	0.971
Subjective socioeconomic status	0.06	0.343	0.02	0.784
Perceived economic inequality			−0.20	0.001
R^2	0.05		0.09	
Adjusted R^2	0.04		0.07	
ΔR^2	0.05		0.04	
F	3.15**		4.54***	

Note. **p < 0.01. ***p < 0.001, two-tailed.

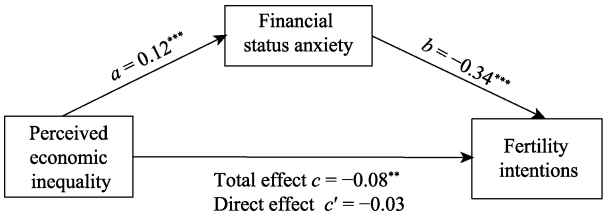


Figure 3. Mediating Role of Financial Status Anxiety in Study 3 (N = 288)

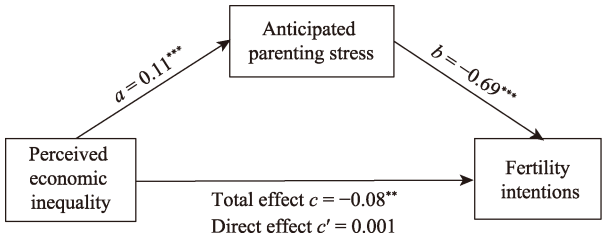


Figure 4. Mediating Role of Anticipated Parenting Stress in Study 3 (N = 288)

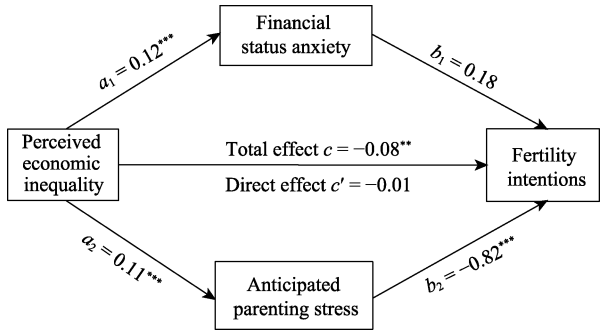


Figure 5. Parallel Mediating Roles of Anticipated Parenting Stress and Financial Status Anxiety in Study 3 (N = 288)

4.3 Discussion

Study 3 used a questionnaire survey to further elucidate the psychological mechanisms through which perceived economic inequality was associated with fertility intentions. The results showed that perceived economic inequality significantly and negatively predicted fertility intentions, again supporting Hypothesis 1. In addition, perceived economic inequality was indirectly associated with lower fertility intentions through higher financial status anxiety, supporting Hypothesis 2, and through greater anticipated parenting stress, supporting Hypothesis 3. Notably, although the indirect effect through financial status anxiety was significant when examined separately, it was no longer significant in the parallel mediation model. One possible explanation is the relatively high correlation between financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress (r = 0.73). When both mediators were entered simultaneously, anticipated parenting stress may have accounted for more of the variance in fertility intentions because of its stronger association with fertility intentions (r = −0.49) than that of financial status anxiety (r = −0.29), thereby reducing the unique explanatory contribution of financial status anxiety.

To rule out the possibility that multicollinearity distorted the estimates in the parallel mediation model, we further calculated the variance inflation factor (VIF) for financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress. The VIF was 2.14, well below the commonly used threshold of 10 (O'Brien, 2007), indicating that serious multicollinearity was not present. Thus, the non-significant indirect effect of financial status anxiety in the parallel mediation model was unlikely to have resulted from excessive overlap between the two mediators and may instead reflect its relatively limited unique explanatory contribution to fertility intentions.

Taken together, these findings suggest that, among the psychological mechanisms linking perceived economic inequality to fertility intentions, individuals' expectations concerning the future burdens of raising children may provide a stronger and more robust explanation than anxiety about their own financial status. To establish causal relationships among the focal variables more rigorously, Study 4 experimentally manipulated perceived economic inequality to examine its causal effect on fertility intentions and to retest the proposed mediating mechanisms.

5 Study 4A (Experimental Study): Causal Evidence for the Effect of Perceived Economic Inequality on Fertility Intentions

Study 4A used a one-factor between-subjects design to examine the causal effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions and to test the mediating roles of financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress. Because individuals' perceptions of inequality in real-world societies may be influenced by prior experiences and the circumstances of people around them, we employed a hypothetical-society paradigm to manipulate perceived economic inequality, thereby allowing for a cleaner estimate of its causal effect (Sánchez-Rodríguez et al., 2026). To enhance the transparency and reliability of the study, the experiment was preregistered on a third-party platform before data collection. The preregistration specified the experimental procedure, measures, and planned sample size (preregistration: https://aspredicted.org/ djvv-84ry.pdf). Preregistration helps enhance the objectivity and credibility of experimental research (Moore, 2016).

5.1 Method

5.1.1 Participants

The required sample size was determined using a Monte Carlo power analysis (Schoemann et al., 2017). Based on prior research (Mao et al., 2026; Cheng et al., 2024) and the results of Study 3, the correlations among perceived economic inequality, financial status anxiety, anticipated parenting stress, and fertility intentions were each set to r = 0.30, and the standard deviation of each variable was set to 0.10. The simulation indicated that at least 233 participants were required to achieve statistical power of 0.80.

A total of 288 childless adults aged 18–35 were recruited through the Credamo platform. Eight participants who failed the attention check, nine participants who did not meet the age criterion (> 35 years), and 34 participants who already had children were excluded. The final sample consisted of 237 participants, including 145 women, with a mean age of 26.78 years (SD = 3.23).

5.1.2 Experimental Procedure

We used a well-established experimental paradigm to manipulate perceived economic inequality (Tanjitpiyanond et al., 2022). Participants were randomly assigned to either the high-inequality condition (n = 115) or the low-inequality condition (n = 122). They first read background information about a hypothetical country to which they were asked to imagine

immigrating. The information described the country's population size, cultural heritage, food and customs, climate, and public transportation system.

Participants were then presented with information about economic inequality in six anonymous countries, with the Gini coefficient used as the indicator of inequality. In the high-inequality condition, participants were told that they had immigrated to the country with the highest Gini coefficient, where the wealth held by the richest 5% of the population was approximately 150 times that held by the poorest 5%. In the low-inequality condition, participants were told that they had immigrated to the country with the lowest Gini coefficient, where the wealth held by the richest 5% was approximately 1.5 times that held by the poorest 5%. In both conditions, participants were told that their current household economic position was around the middle of the social distribution.

The effectiveness of the economic inequality manipulation was then assessed using two items: "How large is the wealth gap between different income groups in the country to which you immigrated?" (1 = *very small*, 7 = *very large*) and "How unequal is the distribution of wealth in this country?" (1 = *very equal*, 7 = *very unequal*). The two items were highly correlated, $r = 0.97$.

Participants then completed the remaining measures. Financial status anxiety, anticipated parenting stress, and fertility intentions were assessed using the same scales as in Study 3. Cronbach's α values were 0.97, 0.97, and 0.98, respectively. Finally, participants completed the same demographic measures as in Study 3. At the end of the experiment, participants were thanked and debriefed regarding the true purpose of the study.

5.2 Results

Data were analyzed using SPSS 26.0. First, an independent-samples t test showed that participants in the high- inequality condition perceived significantly greater economic inequality ($M = 6.69$, $SD = 0.70$) than those in the low-inequality condition ($M = 1.64$, $SD = 0.61$), $t(235) = 59.23$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 7.70$. This result confirmed the effectiveness of the experimental manipulation. Second, independent-samples t tests showed that the manipulation significantly affected financial status anxiety, anticipated parenting stress, and fertility intentions. For financial status anxiety, participants in the high-inequality condition reported significantly greater financial status anxiety ($M = 5.88$, $SD = 0.87$) than those in the low-inequality condition ($M = 2.33$, $SD = 1.01$), $t(235) = 28.96$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 3.76$. This effect remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 230) = 809.55$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .78$.

For anticipated parenting stress, participants in the high-inequality condition reported significantly greater anticipated parenting stress ($M = 5.89$, $SD = 0.74$) than those in the low-inequality condition ($M = 2.49$, $SD = 1.04$), $t(235) = 29.16$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 3.75$. This effect also remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 230) = 818.04$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = .78$.

For fertility intentions, participants in the high-inequality condition reported significantly lower fertility intentions ($M = 3.26$, $SD = 1.72$) than those in the low-inequality condition ($M = 5.76$, $SD = 0.93$), $t(235) = -13.79$, $p < .001$, Cohen's $d = -1.82$. This effect remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 230) = 212.91$, $p < .001$, $\eta_p^2 = .48$.

To test Hypotheses 2 and 3, we conducted mediation analyses using the PROCESS macro developed by Hayes (2013; Model 4) with 5,000 bootstrap samples. Gender, age, educational attainment, subjective socioeconomic status, and income were included as covariates.

The indirect effect through financial status anxiety was significant, $b = 1.20$, $SE = 0.32$, 95% CI [0.63, 1.91] (see Figure 6). This finding indicated that perceived economic inequality was indirectly associated with lower fertility intentions through increased financial status anxiety.

The indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was also significant, $b = 1.56$, $SE = 0.33$, 95% CI [0.98, 2.29] (see Figure 7). This finding indicated that perceived economic inequality was indirectly associated with lower fertility intentions through increased anticipated parenting stress.

Finally, to compare the relative importance of financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, we tested a parallel mediation model in which both mediators were entered simultaneously. As shown in Figure 8, the direct effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions was significant, $b = 0.93$, $SE = 0.37$, 95% CI [0.20, 1.66]. The indirect effect through financial status anxiety was not significant, $b = 0.11$, 95% CI [−0.76, 1.00], whereas the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was significant, $b = 1.47$, 95% CI [0.69, 2.49]. These findings again suggest that, when the two psychological pathways were considered simultaneously,

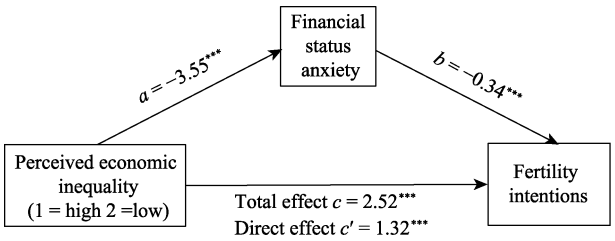


Figure 6. Mediating Role of Financial Status Anxiety in Study 4A ($N = 237$)

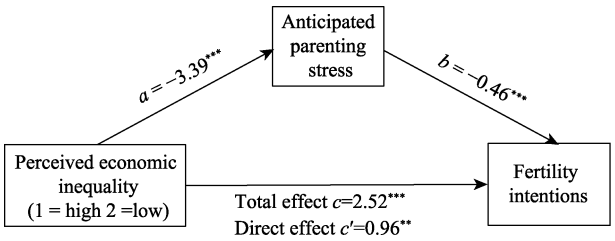


Figure 7. Mediating Role of Anticipated Parenting Stress in Study 4A ($N = 237$)

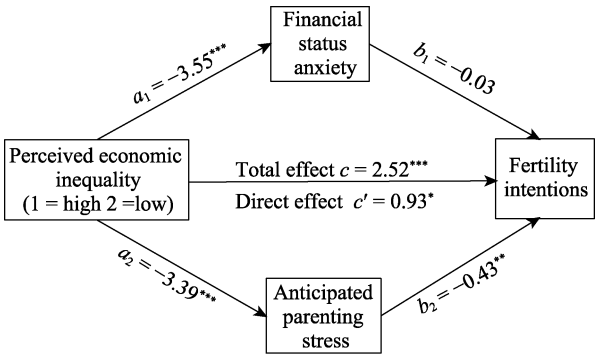


Figure 8. Parallel Mediating Roles of Anticipated Parenting Stress and Financial Status Anxiety in Study 4A ($N = 237$)

anticipated parenting stress was the more central mechanism linking perceived economic inequality to fertility intentions.

5.3 Discussion

By experimentally manipulating perceived economic inequality, Study 4A provided causal evidence that greater perceived economic inequality reduces fertility intentions, further supporting Hypothesis 1. The mediation analyses showed that perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions indirectly through increased financial status anxiety, supporting Hypothesis 2, and through increased anticipated parenting stress, supporting Hypothesis 3. Consistent with the findings of Study 3, however, only the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress remained significant in the parallel mediation model. This finding further suggests that anticipated parenting stress may represent the more central and consistently supported psychological mechanism through which perceived economic inequality influences fertility intentions. To further assess the robustness and replicability of these findings and to examine whether they generalize across cultural contexts, we conducted Study 4B.

6 Study 4B (Cross-Cultural Experiment): A Cross-Cultural Test of the Effect of Perceived Economic Inequality on Fertility Intentions

Study 4B also adopted a one-factor between-subjects design and experimentally manipulated perceived economic inequality to test its causal effect on fertility intentions and the proposed mediating mechanisms. This study had two primary aims. First, to examine the cross-cultural generalizability of the theoretical model, we recruited a sample of childless adults of reproductive age in the United States and tested whether the effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions would replicate in a different cultural context. Second, to extend the experimental methodology used in Study 4A, which relied primarily on information about a hypothetical society, Study 4B incorporated a concrete consumption-choice task to increase participants' situational involvement, strengthen the manipulation, and reduce potential method bias associated with a single mode of information presentation. The experiment was preregistered before data collection (see https://aspredicted.org/2rt6-5dcq.pdf).

6.1 Method

6.1.1 Participants

As in Study 4A, the required sample size was determined using a Monte Carlo power analysis (Schoemann et al., 2017). The analysis indicated that at least 233 participants were required to achieve statistical power of .80. Participants aged 18–35 in the United States were recruited through Prolific. A total of 255 responses were collected. After excluding five participants who already had children, the final sample consisted of 250 participants, including 142 women, with a mean age of 29.05 years (SD = 3.79).

6.1.2 Experimental Procedure

Participants were asked to imagine that they lived in a fictitious society called Bimboola. In this society, residents' annual incomes were divided into three groups: Group 1, Group 2, and Group 3 (Cheng et al., 2024; Sánchez-Rodríguez et al., 2019). In the high-inequality condition, the annual incomes of Groups 1, 2, and 3 were 77,000, 40,000, and 3,000 Bimboolean dollars (BD), respectively. In the low-inequality condition, the corresponding annual incomes were 50,000, 40,000, and 30,000 BD. In both conditions, participants were told that they belonged to Group 2. There were 128 participants in the high-inequality condition and 122 in the low-inequality condition.

To enhance the realism and involvement of the economic inequality manipulation, participants completed a consumption-choice task in Bimboola. They were asked to select three necessities—a house, a car, and a vacation—from sets of options corresponding to different income groups. In the high-inequality condition, the options available to Group 1 were considerably more luxurious, whereas those available to Group 3 were substantially more modest. The options available to Group 2 were held constant across the two experimental conditions. Because all participants were assigned to Group 2, they could choose only from the options available to Groups 2 and 3 and could not afford any Group 1 options.

Participants then completed two manipulation-check items: "How unequal is the distribution of wealth in Bimboola?" (1 = *very equal*, 7 = *very unequal*) and "How equal is the distribution of wealth in Bimboola?" (1 = *very unequal*, 7 = *very equal*), with the second item reverse-scored. The two items were highly correlated, r = 0.92. In addition, to ensure that participants understood the experimental scenario, an attention-check item asked, "Which income group were you assigned to in Bimboola?" Participants selected from Groups 1, 2, and 3, and responses from those who answered incorrectly were excluded.

After the manipulation check, participants completed measures of financial status anxiety, anticipated parenting stress, and fertility intentions using the same scales as in Study 3. Cronbach's α values were 0.94, 0.95, and 0.99, respectively. Participants then provided demographic information. At the end of the study, they were thanked and debriefed regarding the true purpose of the experiment.

6.2 Results

6.2.1 Cross-Cultural Applicability of the Measures

To examine whether the measures were appropriate for use in the U.S. sample, we evaluated the construct validity of the Fertility Intention Scale (Chen et al., 2024) and the self-developed Anticipated Parenting Stress Scale. Confirmatory factor analyses indicated that the fertility intentions measure demonstrated good model fit, $\chi^2(7) = 15.80$, CFI = 0.99, TLI = 0.99, RMSEA = 0.07. The two-factor model of anticipated parenting stress also demonstrated good fit, $\chi^2(19) = 41.78$, CFI = 0.99, TLI = 0.98, RMSEA = 0.07. These results indicated satisfactory construct validity for both measures in the U.S. sample.

To further assess the cross-cultural equivalence of the measures, we conducted measurement invariance analyses using the Chinese sample from Study 4A and the U.S. sample from Study 4B. Multigroup confirmatory factor analyses showed that the configural invariance model, χ^2 = 1053.63, df = 298, CFI = 0.95, RMSEA = 0.07, and the metric invariance model, χ^2 = 1103.51, df = 314, CFI = 0.95, RMSEA = 0.07, differed in CFI by only 0.002, which was below the recommended threshold of .01. These results supported both configural and metric invariance across the Chinese and U.S. samples. After equality constraints were additionally imposed on the item intercepts, the scalar invariance model continued to show acceptable fit, CFI = 0.94, RMSEA = 0.08. Relative to the metric invariance model, ΔCFI = 0.008 (< 0.01) and ΔRMSEA = 0.003 (< .015), both of which fell within recommended criteria (Chen, 2007; Cheung & Rensvold, 2002). Thus, the measures also

the measures also demonstrated scalar invariance across the Chinese and U.S. samples, providing evidence of good cross-cultural structural equivalence. All analyses were conducted using Mplus 8.3.

6.2.2 Manipulation Check and Hypothesis Testing

Data were analyzed using SPSS 26.0. An independent-samples t test showed that participants in the high- inequality condition (M = 6.52, SD = 0.95) reported significantly greater perceived economic inequality than those in the low-inequality condition (M = 2.55, SD = 1.23), $t(248) = 28.42$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 3.62$, confirming the effectiveness of the experimental manipulation.

Independent-samples t tests further showed that the economic inequality manipulation significantly affected financial status anxiety, anticipated parenting stress, and fertility intentions. For financial status anxiety, participants in the high-inequality condition (M = 5.01, SD = 1.34) reported significantly greater financial status anxiety than those in the low-inequality condition (M = 2.95, SD = 1.41), $t(248) = 11.87$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.50$. This effect remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 243) = 134.56$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = .36$. For anticipated parenting stress, participants in the high-inequality condition (M = 5.38, SD = 1.23) reported significantly greater anticipated parenting stress than those in the low-inequality condition (M = 3.49, SD = 1.46), $t(248) = 11.14$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = 1.41$. This effect remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 243) = 119.31$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = .33$. For fertility intentions, participants in the high-inequality condition (M = 3.36, SD = 1.98) reported significantly lower fertility intentions than those in the low-inequality condition (M = 4.45, SD = 2.02), $t(248) = -4.28$, $p < 0.001$, Cohen's $d = -0.54$. This effect also remained significant after controlling for demographic variables, $F(1, 243) = 19.62$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.07$.

To examine the mediating role of financial status anxiety, we conducted a mediation analysis using the PROCESS macro for SPSS developed by Hayes (2013; Model 4) with 5,000 bootstrap samples. Gender, age, subjective socioeconomic status, educational attainment, and income were included as covariates. As shown in Figure 9, the indirect effect through financial status anxiety was significant, b = 0.76, SE = 0.20, 95% CI [0.39, 1.16], indicating that perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions through increased financial status anxiety.

We next examined the mediating role of anticipated parenting stress using the same analytical procedure. As shown in Figure 10, the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was significant, b = 1.29, SE = 0.18, 95% CI [0.95, 1.66], indicating that perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions through increased anticipated parenting stress.

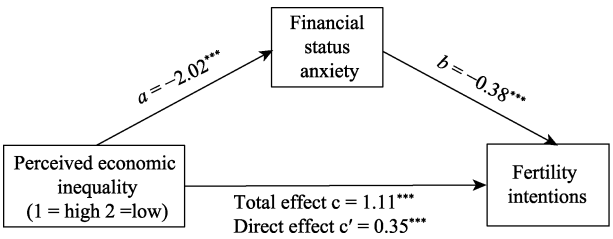


Figure 9. Mediating Role of Financial Status Anxiety in Study 4B (N = 250)

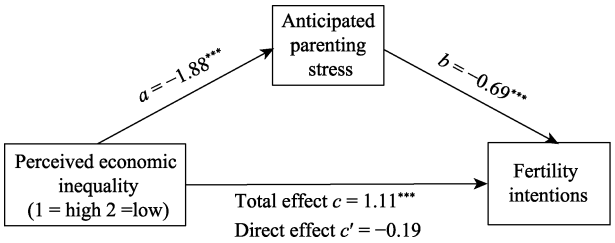


Figure 10. Mediating Role of Anticipated Parenting Stress in Study 4B (N = 250)

Finally, to examine the parallel mediating roles of financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, we conducted a PROCESS Model 4 analysis with experimental condition as the predictor, financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress as parallel mediators, and fertility intentions as the outcome variable. Gender, age, subjective socioeconomic status, educational attainment, and income were included as covariates, and 5,000 bootstrap samples were used. As shown in Figure 11, the direct effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions was not significant, b = −0.04, SE = 0.28, 95% CI [−0.60, 0.51]. Of the two indirect pathways, the indirect effect through financial status anxiety was not significant, b = −0.41, 95% CI [−0.89, 0.03], whereas the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was significant, b = 1.57, 95% CI [1.10, 2.08]. These findings again indicate that anticipated parenting stress provided a stronger explanation for how perceived economic inequality influenced fertility intentions.

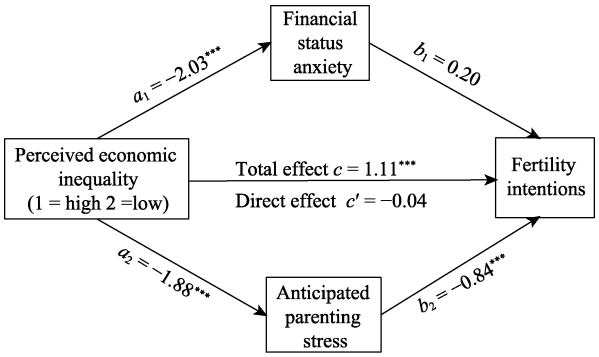


Figure 11. Parallel Mediating Roles of Financial Status Anxiety and Anticipated Parenting Stress in Study 4B (N = 250)

6.2.3 Cross-Cultural Differences

To further examine whether the focal effects differed across cultural contexts, we combined the Chinese sample from Study 4A and the U.S. sample from Study 4B and conducted separate 2 (economic inequality: high vs. low) × 2 (cultural group: China vs. United States) analyses of covariance for fertility intentions, financial status anxiety, and anticipated parenting stress. Age, gender, educational attainment, income level, and subjective socioeconomic status were included as covariates in all analyses. Figure 12 displays the mean patterns for the three dependent variables across economic inequality conditions and cultural groups.

For fertility intentions, the interaction between economic inequality condition and cultural group was significant, $F(1, 475) = 19.37$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.04$. Simple-effects analyses showed that fertility intentions were significantly lower in the high-inequality condition than in the low-inequality condition in both China and the United States, but the effect was stronger

in the Chinese sample (China: $B = -2.52$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.48$; United States: $B = -1.11$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.08$). For financial status anxiety, the interaction between economic inequality condition and cultural group was also significant, $F(1, 475) = 50.01$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.10$. Simple-effects analyses showed that financial status anxiety was significantly higher in the high-inequality condition than in the low-inequality condition in both cultural groups, but the effect was stronger in the Chinese sample (China: $B = 3.55$, $\eta_p^2 = .78$; United States: $B = 2.01$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.35$). For anticipated parenting stress, the interaction between economic inequality condition and cultural group was likewise significant, $F(1, 475) = 52.79$, $p < 0.001$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.10$. Simple-effects analyses showed that anticipated parenting stress was significantly higher in the high-inequality condition than in the low- inequality condition in both China and the United States, but the effect was again stronger in the Chinese sample (China: $B = 3.39$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.78$; United States: $B = 1.86$, $\eta_p^2 = 0.33$).

Taken together, these results indicate that the suppressive effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions, as well as its amplifying effects on financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, was stronger in the Chinese sample than in the U.S. sample.

6.3 Discussion

Study 4B successfully replicated the findings of Study 4A in a U.S. sample, providing further evidence for the cross-cultural robustness of the negative effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions and its underlying psychological mechanisms. Consistent with Studies 3 and 4A, Study 4B again showed that anticipated parenting stress had greater explanatory power than financial status anxiety. The cross-cultural comparison further revealed that these effects were significantly stronger in the Chinese sample than in the U.S. sample. Thus, although the effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions appeared to be robust across cultural contexts, its magnitude varied as a function of cultural background.

Taken together, Studies 4A and 4B employed different experimental manipulations and samples from two cultural contexts, China and the United States. Their convergent findings strengthen the methodological robustness, replicability, and cross-cultural generalizability of the results and provide more comprehensive empirical support for Hypotheses 1 through 3.

7 General Discussion

In recent years, rapid economic development and social structural change have made wealth disparities and income distribution increasingly salient social issues. Such macro-level inequality has gradually permeated individuals' subjective experiences and may, in turn, shape major life decisions, including whether to have children. As the gap between the rich and the poor widens, perceived pressures surrounding resource allocation, expectations about children's future competitive environments, and rising childrearing costs become increasingly intertwined with individuals' subjective interpretations of inequality. Against this backdrop, the growing prevalence of being "afraid to have children" or "unwilling to have children" reflects not only evaluations of one's objective economic circumstances, but also psychological adaptation and strategic responses to a particular social ecology.

Drawing on a socioecological psychological perspective, the present research systematically examined the effects of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions and the psychological mechanisms underlying these effects across four studies comprising five component studies. Specifically, Study 1 used large-scale social media text analysis and revealed a significant positive association between expressed economic inequality and low fertility intentions in naturally occurring public discourse. Study 2 used nationally representative survey data to replicate this relationship at the individual level, providing further support for the basic hypothesis. Study 3 used a questionnaire survey to investigate the underlying psychological mechanisms and found that perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions through greater financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress. Importantly, in the parallel mediation model, only the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress remained consistently significant, suggesting that expectations concerning future parenting responsibilities may be more important for fertility decisions than anxiety about one's own financial status. To establish causality and examine the cross-cultural generalizability of the model, Studies 4A and 4B employed different experimental paradigms with Chinese and U.S. samples, respectively. Both studies provided causal evidence that perceived economic inequality reduced fertility intentions and again supported the central mediating role of anticipated parenting stress. Taken together, these findings suggest that perceived economic inequality may suppress fertility intentions through two psychological pathways: anxiety about maintaining one's own financial status, which we conceptualize as the intragenerational status-maintenance pathway, and anticipated pressure associated with future childrearing responsibilities, which we conceptualize as the intergenerational responsibility-anticipation pathway. Of these two pathways, the latter emerged as the more central and consistently supported mechanism.

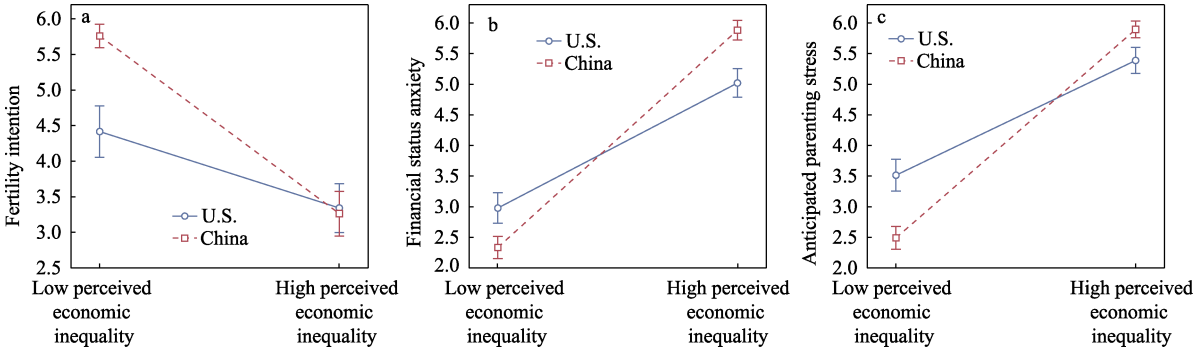


Figure 12. Interaction Effects of Economic Inequality and Cultural Group on Fertility Intentions, Financial Status Anxiety, and Anticipated Parenting Stress

7.1 Theoretical Implications

First, the present research incorporates a macro-level social structural factor into the explanatory framework of fertility decision-making, thereby extending understanding of the antecedents of fertility intentions. Previous research has largely examined fertility intentions in relation to individual characteristics, family resources, and macro-level policies (Wan & Chen, 2024; Wang et al., 2024; Zhai et al., 2025; Lan et al., 2025). These perspectives often implicitly assume a process of relatively rational calculation, in which individuals objectively evaluate their available resources, childrearing costs, and time constraints. However, they pay comparatively less attention to the subjective construction of resources and costs. In other words, individuals' evaluations of their current economic circumstances, future parenting capacity, and the feasibility of having children depend not only on their absolute level of resources but also on the broader social ecology in which they are embedded. By introducing perceived economic inequality into the antecedent framework of fertility intentions, the present research identifies a sociopsychological pathway that differs from traditional resource-constraint explanations. Economic inequality may influence fertility decisions not only by altering objective resource conditions, but also by reshaping individuals' subjective assessments of whether their current resources are sufficient and how much investment future parenting will require. This perspective moves beyond a linear "more resources versus fewer resources" account of fertility and conceptualizes fertility decision-making as an adaptive sociopsychological process embedded in social comparison and subjective cognitive appraisal.

Second, the present research extends the psychological and behavioral consequences of economic inequality to the major life-course domain of fertility decision-making. Previous research has focused primarily on the effects of economic inequality on relatively immediate, short-term decisions, such as risk taking and consumption behavior (Álamo-Hernández et al., 2025; Cheng et al., 2026; Payne et al., 2017; Velandia-Morales et al., 2022). In contrast, whether and how inequality shapes long-term life decisions—particularly fertility, which involves substantial intertemporal investment and intergenerational consequences—has received far less systematic attention. The present findings show that the psychological consequences of economic inequality are not confined to immediate behavioral preferences but can extend into long-term life planning. In doing so, this research broadens the literature on economic inequality from short-term behavioral responses to consequential life-course choices and deepens theoretical understanding of the broader social consequences of inequality.

Third, the present research develops and tests a dual-process psychological model involving an intragenerational status-maintenance pathway and an intergenerational responsibility-anticipation pathway. Specifically, perceived economic inequality may first create a social-cognitive climate characterized by competition and uncertainty and then operate through two distinct pathways. In the intragenerational pathway, social comparison heightens concerns and anxiety about one's own financial status, prompting individuals to devote more resources to career advancement and wealth accumulation and thereby reducing the resources available for childbearing. In the intergenerational pathway, pessimistic expectations about future opportunity structures activate concerns about downward mobility and a logic of competitive parenting, substantially increasing the anticipated burden of future investments in children. Together, these pathways create psychological barriers to childbearing.

Importantly, anticipated parenting stress played a more stable and central role in fertility decision-making than financial status anxiety, and this pattern was observed in both Chinese and U.S. samples. One possible explanation is that financial status anxiety may influence fertility intentions relatively indirectly through behavioral adjustments, such as greater investment in work, whereas anticipated parenting stress more directly changes individuals' cost–benefit assessments of raising children and therefore constitutes a more proximal mechanism of fertility decision-making. More importantly, the anticipated parenting stress proposed in the present research differs from parenting stress that arises simply from resource scarcity. Rather, it reflects anxiety about children's future socioeconomic competition that is intensified in highly unequal societies. Under conditions of high inequality, parenting may come to resemble an "arms race" aimed at preventing children from experiencing downward mobility or enabling them to achieve upward mobility. Anticipated parenting stress therefore represents a prospective psychological burden arising from individuals' evaluations of whether they can afford the substantial financial and effort-related investments required to participate in this competition. This may help explain why some young adults with relatively stable economic circumstances nevertheless choose to delay or forgo childbearing.

In addition, the present research found that the direct suppressive effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions was broadly consistent across social-class groups (see Appendix 1). Previous studies have largely emphasized the direct constraints imposed by objective economic conditions, such as income and childrearing costs, on fertility decisions (Brea-Martínez & Dribe, 2025; Lan et al., 2025). Our findings suggest that the psychological effects of economic inequality may extend beyond objective class boundaries and develop into a more diffuse form of structural pressure and broader social climate. In other words, even relatively resource-advantaged individuals may scale back their fertility plans in response to expectations of intense social competition. This finding reinforces the central argument of the present research and provides a theoretical basis for future work examining whether improvements in the broader social environment, rather than subsidies targeted only at specific groups, may help support fertility intentions.

Finally, the suppressive effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions, as well as its amplifying effects on financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress, was stronger in the Chinese sample than in the U.S. sample. This finding provides additional evidence for contextual variation in these mechanisms across sociocultural settings. One possible explanation concerns differences in cultural orientation. Compared with individualistic cultures, which emphasize independent self-construal and personal choice, collectivistic cultures place greater emphasis on interdependence, family obligations, and responsibility. Western cultures are generally considered more oriented toward the former, whereas East Asian cultures tend to be more oriented toward the latter (Markus & Kitayama, 1991; Singelis et al., 1995; Triandis, 1995). Previous research has shown that Chinese participants endorse collectivistic values more strongly

vistic values more strongly than U.S. participants (Imamura & Zhang, 2012), and these cultural differences are also reflected in parenting values. In U.S. samples, higher social class is more consistently associated with valuing self-directed qualities such as independence and imagination, whereas in Chinese samples it is more strongly associated with valuing other-oriented qualities such as responsibility, respect, and selflessness (Chen et al., 2022). Thus, in the relatively more collectivistically oriented Chinese context, individuals confronting economic inequality may be more likely not only to consider their own resource circumstances but also to connect inequality with family security, intergenerational support, and responsibility, thereby producing a stronger suppressive effect on fertility intentions.

7.2 Practical Implications

First, although the present research focuses on individuals' psychological perceptions, these perceptions are fundamentally psychological representations of macro-level social structures. Persistently low fertility intentions should therefore not be viewed solely as a matter of individual choice; they may also reflect adaptive psychological responses to the structure of social resource distribution. Accordingly, in addition to financial subsidies and efforts to shape fertility-related attitudes, fertility-support policies may need to respond more directly to the psychological pressures experienced by childless young adults within the broader social environment.

The present research shows that perceived economic inequality heightens concerns about one's own financial status, which in turn may weaken fertility intentions. Thus, understanding fertility decisions among childless adults of reproductive age requires attention to their experiences of social comparison and the resulting status anxiety. Public communication concerning youth development and family life could provide more diverse frames of reference and avoid overemphasizing external markers such as wealth, consumption capacity, or social status. Doing so may help reduce delays in fertility decision-making that arise from pressure surrounding relative financial position.

More importantly, the present findings indicate that childless adults may already form concrete expectations, before having children, about the future financial and effort-related costs of raising children. Compared with intragenerational financial status anxiety, this intergenerational form of anticipated parenting stress showed a stronger suppressive association with fertility intentions. Fertility-support communication may therefore benefit from addressing individuals' expectations about future costs more directly. For example, improving the clarity, stability, and accessibility of childcare and family-support policies may allow prospective parents to form clearer and more predictable expectations about future parenting responsibilities.

Moreover, because greater perceived inequality may amplify concerns about children's downward mobility and expectations surrounding "successful parenting," public discourse could reduce overly narrow narratives linking educational competition to upward social mobility and avoid excessively promoting hypercompetitive parenting cultures. Instead, a more supportive and pluralistic view of child development may help reduce anticipated parenting stress before childbearing, strengthen individuals' perceived control and confidence regarding future family life, and thereby address one important source of the contemporary reluctance to have children.

7.3 Limitations and Future Directions

First, the present research used self-reported fertility intentions as the primary outcome variable. Although fertility intentions significantly predict subsequent fertility behavior (Liang et al., 2025), intentions and actual behavior do not always correspond perfectly (Qiu et al., 2019). Future research could combine longitudinal panel data with population registration records to examine the long-term effects of perceived economic inequality on actual fertility behavior and the mechanisms underlying these effects, thereby enhancing the ecological validity of the conclusions.

Second, the present research primarily identified the direct and indirect pathways through which perceived economic inequality may influence fertility intentions. Future research could further investigate the boundary conditions of these effects. For example, stronger beliefs in social mobility may buffer the negative effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions. When individuals believe that the opportunity structure of society is relatively open, the status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress elicited by inequality may be attenuated, making them more willing to consider having children. Conversely, when individuals perceive social class boundaries as rigid and mobility opportunities as limited, inequality may be more readily interpreted as an insurmountable structural barrier, thereby strengthening the tendency to avoid childbearing. Social support from families and communities, as well as cultural norms emphasizing family values, may play similar moderating roles. Future studies could incorporate these factors into the model to provide a more comprehensive account of the individual differences and contextual conditions under which economic inequality shapes fertility intentions.

Third, the present research examined financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress as parallel mediators, focusing on the unique indirect effect of each while controlling for the other. However, this modeling strategy does not imply that the two psychological responses are temporally independent or incapable of influencing one another. On the one hand, concerns about insufficient or declining financial status may make individuals more sensitive to whether they will be able to afford the financial and effort-related demands of future childrearing, thereby increasing anticipated parenting stress. On the other hand, worries about future parenting investments and responsibilities may, in turn, intensify anxiety about insufficient or declining financial status. Future research could use longitudinal designs, experience-sampling methods, or sequential experimental designs to examine the possible temporal ordering, reciprocal effects, and dynamic interplay between these two psychological responses, thereby providing a more fine-grained account of how perceived economic inequality is psychologically translated into fertility intentions.

Finally, beyond examining individual-level boundary conditions, future research could further expand the cross-cultural investigation of the effects of economic inequality. By comparing Chinese and U.S. samples, the present research provided initial evidence that the effects of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions and the underlying psychological mechanisms may vary across cultural contexts. Future studies could include a broader range of countries and regions with different cultural traditions and socioecological conditions to examine both the universality and cultural specificity of these effects and to identify the sources of cross-cultural variation.

For example, future work could investigate the roles of social policy environments, gender roles, and the division of family labor in shaping these processes, thereby developing a more comprehensive understanding of the cultural and socioecological mechanisms through which economic inequality influences fertility intentions.

8 Conclusion

Across four studies comprising five component studies, the present research integrated large-scale social media data analysis, a nationally representative survey, a questionnaire study, and cross-cultural experiments to systematically examine the effects of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions and the psychological mechanisms underlying these effects. The findings showed that (1) greater perceived economic inequality was associated with lower fertility intentions; (2) financial status anxiety and anticipated parenting stress each served as mediating mechanisms; and (3) anticipated parenting stress emerged as the stronger and more consistently supported pathway.

By linking the macro-level socioecological environment to micro-level fertility decision-making from a social psychological perspective, the present research identifies two psychological pathways—the intragenerational status-maintenance pathway and the intergenerational responsibility-anticipation pathway—through which perceived economic inequality may shape fertility intentions. These findings deepen understanding of the psychological foundations of low fertility and provide theoretical and practical implications for building a more fertility-supportive society.

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Supplementary Materials

Appendix 1

Moderating Effects of Socioeconomic Status

To examine whether socioeconomic status (both subjective and objective) moderated the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions, we conducted supplementary analyses based on the data from Study 3. These analyses included tests of moderation of the direct effect and moderated mediation models, as summarized in Supplementary Table 1.

1 Moderation of the Direct Effect

PROCESS Model 1 was used to separately examine whether subjective socioeconomic status (SES) and objective income level moderated the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions.

1.1 Subjective Socioeconomic Status as the Moderator

After controlling for income, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and subjective SES did not significantly predict fertility intentions, $b = -0.04$, $SE = 0.074$, $t = -0.59$, $p = 0.558$, 95% CI [−0.19, 0.10]. Thus, subjective SES did not significantly moderate the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions.

1.2 Objective Income Level as the Moderator

After controlling for subjective SES, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and income level did not significantly predict fertility intentions, $b = -0.08$, $SE = 0.12$, $t = -0.64$, $p = 0.524$, 95% CI [−0.31, 0.16]. Thus, objective income level did not significantly moderate the relationship between perceived economic inequality and fertility intentions.

Taken together, neither subjective SES nor objective income level significantly moderated the direct effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions. Given the absence of moderation on the direct pathway, we further examined whether socioeconomic status might moderate the psychological mechanisms underlying this relationship.

2 Moderation of the Underlying Mechanisms: Moderated Mediation Analyses

2.1 Moderated Mediation Model With Financial Status Anxiety as the Mediator

PROCESS Model 8 was used to separately examine whether subjective SES and objective income level moderated the mediation pathway from perceived economic inequality to financial status anxiety and, in turn, to fertility intentions.

When subjective SES was examined as the moderator, controlling for income, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and subjective SES did not significantly predict financial status anxiety, $b = 0.01$, $SE = 0.05$, $t = 0.23$, $p = 0.815$, 95% CI [−0.08, 0.11].

Conditional indirect-effect analyses showed that the indirect effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions through financial status anxiety was significant at low SES, *effect* = −0.16, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.27, −0.07]; mean SES, *effect* = −0.17, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.26, −0.08]; and high SES, *effect* = −0.17, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.28, −0.08]. The index of moderated mediation was −0.00, $SE = 0.02$, 95% CI [−0.04, 0.04]. Because the confidence interval included zero, subjective SES did not significantly moderate this indirect effect.

A parallel analysis using objective income level as the moderator yielded the same pattern of results. After controlling for subjective SES, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and annual income did not significantly predict financial status anxiety, $b = 0.03$, $SE = 0.08$, $t = 0.36$, $p = 0.716$, 95% CI [−0.13, 0.18].

The indirect effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions through financial status anxiety was significant at low income, *effect* = −0.16, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.26, −0.08]; mean income, *effect* = −0.16, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.26, −0.08]; and high income, *effect* = −0.17, $SE = 0.05$, 95% CI [−0.29, −0.08]. The index of moderated mediation was −0.01, $SE = 0.03$, 95% CI [−0.08, 0.05]. Because this confidence interval also included zero, objective income did not significantly moderate the indirect effect.

Taken together, neither subjective SES nor objective income significantly moderated the mediation pathway from perceived economic inequality through financial status anxiety to fertility intentions, suggesting that this psychological mechanism was broadly consistent across socioeconomic strata.

2.2 Moderated Mediation Model With Anticipated Parenting Stress as the Mediator

PROCESS Model 8 was also used to separately examine whether subjective SES and objective income level moderated the mediation pathway from perceived economic inequality to anticipated parenting stress and, in turn, to fertility intentions.

When subjective SES was examined as the moderator, controlling for income, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and subjective SES did not significantly predict anticipated parenting stress, $b = 0.01$, $SE = 0.05$, $t = 0.22$, $p = 0.828$, 95% CI [−0.08, 0.10].

Supplementary Table 1. Tests of the Moderating Effects of Social Status

Model/Path	Moderator	Effect Tested	*b*	*SE*	*t*	*p*	95% CI	Index of Moderated Mediation
Model 1: Direct effect	Subjective SES	Economic inequality × subjective SES	−0.04	0.07	−0.59	0.558	[−0.19, 0.10]	
	Objective income	Economic inequality × objective income	−0.08	0.12	−0.64	0.524	[−0.31, 0.16]	
Model 8: Moderated mediation	Subjective SES	Inequality × subjective SES → financial status anxiety	0.01	0.05	0.23	0.815	[−0.08, 0.11]	Index = −0.00 [−0.04, 0.04]
	Objective income	Inequality × income → financial status anxiety	0.03	0.08	0.36	0.716	[−0.13, 0.18]	Index = −0.01 [−0.08, 0.05]
	Subjective SES	Inequality × subjective SES → anticipated parenting stress	0.01	0.05	0.22	0.828	[−0.08, 0.10]	Index = −0.01 [−0.09, 0.07]
	Objective income	Inequality × income → anticipated parenting stress	0.10	0.07	1.34	0.182	[−0.05, 0.24]	Index = −0.07 [−0.20, 0.04]

Note. SES = socioeconomic status. The final column reports the index of moderated mediation and its 95% bootstrap confidence interval.

Conditional indirect-effect analyses showed that the indirect effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions through anticipated parenting stress was significant at low SES, *effect* = −0.29, *SE* = 0.06, 95% CI [−0.43, −0.18]; mean SES, *effect* = −0.30, *SE* = 0.05, 95% CI [−0.41, −0.20]; and high SES, *effect* = −0.31, *SE* = 0.07, 95% CI [−0.45, −0.18]. The index of moderated mediation was −0.01, *SE* = 0.04, 95% CI [−0.09, 0.07]. Because the confidence interval included zero, the strength of the indirect effect did not significantly vary as a function of subjective SES.

A further analysis using objective income level as the moderator produced a similar pattern. After controlling for subjective SES, gender, age, and educational attainment, the interaction between perceived economic inequality and annual income did not significantly predict anticipated parenting stress, *b* = 0.10, *SE* = 0.07, *t* = 1.34, *p* = 0.182, 95% CI [−0.05, 0.24].

Conditional indirect-effect analyses showed that the indirect effect through anticipated parenting stress was significant at low income, *effect* = −0.27, *SE* = 0.06, 95% CI [−0.39, −0.16]; mean income, *effect* = −0.27, *SE* = 0.06, 95% CI [−0.39, −0.16]; and high income, *effect* = −0.34, *SE* = 0.07, 95% CI [−0.49, −0.21]. The index of moderated mediation was −0.07, *SE* = 0.06, 95% CI [−0.20, 0.04]. Because the confidence interval included zero, objective income likewise did not significantly moderate this mediation pathway.

Taken together, neither subjective SES nor objective income level significantly moderated the mediation pathway from perceived economic inequality through anticipated parenting stress to fertility intentions.

3 Summary

Overall, neither subjective socioeconomic status nor objective income level showed significant moderating effects on either the direct effect or the proposed psychological mechanisms. These findings consistently suggest that the negative effect of perceived economic inequality on fertility intentions is broadly similar across socioeconomic strata and does not vary significantly as a function of individuals' social-class position. In other words, the effect does not appear to be confined to any particular socioeconomic group but may instead reflect a more pervasive societal mindset. These findings suggest that the influence of economic inequality on fertility intentions has a broad social basis that extends beyond specific class boundaries, highlighting the pervasive role of macro-level social structures in shaping individual fertility decisions.

Appendix 2

Rater Coding Guidelines

Social Media Text Rating Manual

I General Rating Instructions

1. Core Task

For each tokenized Weibo post, independently assess the strength with which the post expresses perceived economic inequality and low fertility intentions.

2. Independent Rating of the Two Constructs

Each post should be rated separately on the two constructs. A single post may simultaneously express high perceived economic inequality and strong low fertility intentions. Ratings of the two constructs should therefore be made independently.

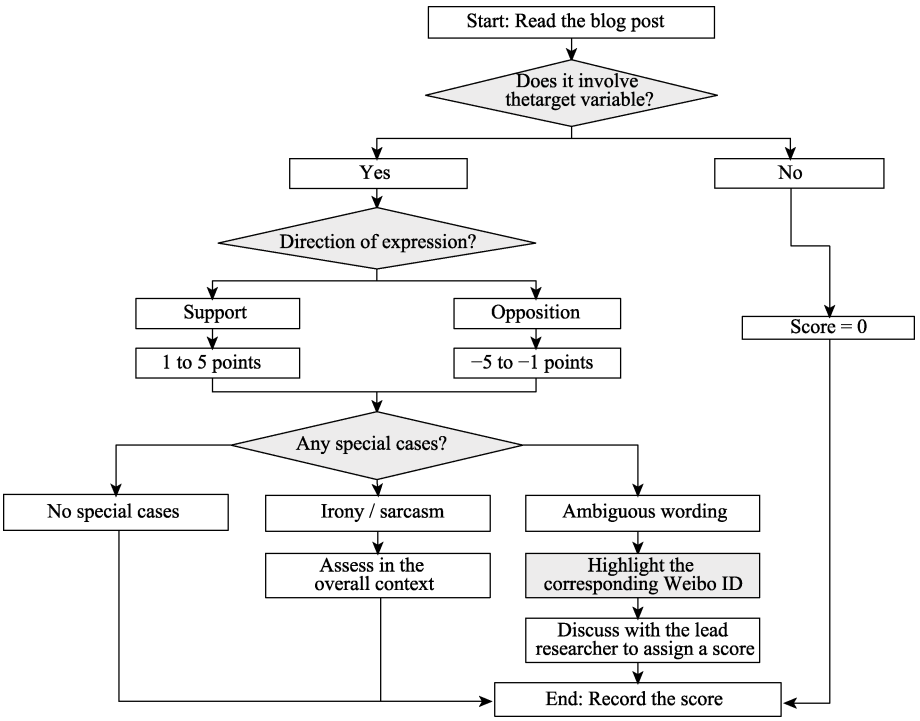
3. Rating Scale

An 11-point scale ranging from −5 to +5 should be used. Scores are assigned as follows:

1. If the post clearly expresses a position that is contrary to or rejects the meaning of the construct, assign a score from −5 to −1.

2. If the post does not address the construct at all, assign a score of 0.

3. If the post addresses and supports or reflects the construct, assign a score from +1 to +5.



Supplementary Figure 1. Flowchart of the Rater Coding Procedure

II Rating Criteria

Construct 1: Perceived Economic Inequality

1. Definition

Perceived economic inequality refers to individuals' subjective perceptions, judgments, or descriptions of unequal distributions of wealth, income, opportunities, and other resources within society. It typically involves references to, reactions to, criticisms of, or discussions of disparities between the rich and the poor.

2. Dictionary Terms

Wealth gap, polarization, income gap, extreme wealth disparity, poor people, rich people, lower class, wealthy people (8 terms in total).

Note. Dictionary terms should be treated as cues for identifying relevant content; final ratings should be based on the overall meaning and context of the complete sentence or passage.

Construct 2: Low Fertility Intentions

1. Definition

Low fertility intentions refer to negative, rejecting, hesitant, or apprehensive attitudes, inclinations, or decisions regarding childbearing.

2. Dictionary Terms

Do not have children, do not want to have children, do not give birth, do not have a baby, should not have children, will not have children, DINK, do not want kids, unwilling to have children, do not want a child, afraid to have children, cannot afford to have children, cannot afford to raise children, do not plan to have children, not prepared to have children, will not want children, and related expressions (26 terms in total).

3. Direction of Scoring

The target construct is the strength of low fertility intentions.

1. Posts expressing unwillingness, fear, or refusal to have children should receive positive scores (+1 to +5).

2. Posts expressing a desire or willingness to have children, or encouraging childbearing, should receive negative scores (−5 to −1).

III Rating Examples

All example posts presented in this manual were drawn from authentic Weibo posts collected in the present research. To protect user privacy, all personally identifying information, including user IDs, was anonymized. The examples are provided solely to illustrate the coding criteria for raters.

Example 1

"Even having one child feels unbearable to me—I really don't want one and have to struggle with myself mentally. A second or third child? ... The gap between the rich and the poor will only become more extreme in the future. Rich people have more children so that not all of them turn out badly, while poor people have more children in the hope that one of them will become a genius.... Even if you have a child, without capital backing them up, all those high-quality resources will only train them to become highly skilled workers...."

Perceived economic inequality: +5 (strongly expresses wealth disparities, class rigidity, and unequal educational resources)

Low fertility intentions: +4 (clearly expresses unwillingness to have children)

Example 2

"Over the past two years, I've increasingly wanted to have a child. I'm not even sure what kind of desire it is.... Maybe I want to build a stronger connection with the world; maybe I want to continue life.... Although I still don't think I'm mature enough, I believe I would become a good mother...."

Perceived economic inequality: 0 (does not mention wealth disparities or resource inequality)

Low fertility intentions: −4 (clearly expresses a desire to have children and therefore represents the opposite of low fertility intentions)

Example 3

"The gap between the rich and the poor is getting wider and wider—wide enough to change how people think about having children.... It's not that being poor means you cannot have children. Not having children isn't simply about money; it's that there are too many rich people in this society, and ordinary people can no longer see any hope."

Perceived economic inequality: +4 (explicitly refers to the wealth gap and the prevalence of wealthy people)

Low fertility intentions: +3 (expresses an attitude toward not having children)

Example 4

"One good thing about the old egalitarian system was that everyone had a secure job. There was no polarization between rich and poor, and there was less anxiety, so every family dared to have children. Unlike today—even if people want children, they are afraid to have them."

Perceived economic inequality: +3 (implies the existence of contemporary wealth inequality)

Low fertility intentions: +3 (explicitly expresses being afraid to have children, indicating low fertility intentions)

Appendix 3

Research Materials

Study 3

Perceived Economic Inequality Scale

1 = Strongly disagree; 7 = Strongly agree

1. Most of the wealth in society goes into the pockets of a small minority.
2. Apart from those at the very top, people have very little money.
3. Only the rich have real opportunities to succeed in life.
4. Only those at the top have wealth.

Fertility Intention Scale

1 = Strongly disagree; 7 = Strongly agree

1. I am willing to have children at some point.
2. Having children is part of my life plan.
3. If possible, I would like to have children of my own.
4. I hope to have children of my own at some point in my life.
5. Looking ahead, I hope to become a father or mother.
6. I look forward to having children of my own one day.

Financial Status Anxiety Scale

1 = Strongly disagree; 7 = Strongly agree

1. I worry that my current financial situation is poor.
2. I worry a great deal that I will find it difficult to achieve my desired financial goals.
3. I worry that my financial situation will not improve.
4. I worry that my financial situation will deteriorate.
5. I worry that I may never be able to change my current social status.

Anticipated Parenting Stress Scale

1 = Strongly disagree; 7 = Strongly agree. The first four items assess anticipated financial stress, and the last four assess anticipated demands on time and energy.

1. I worry that I will struggle to afford the various expenses of raising a child (e.g., education, healthcare, and leisure activities).
2. I feel that raising a child would place me under considerable financial pressure.
3. I worry that my income will not be sufficient to provide ideal conditions for my child's development in the long term.
4. The thought of the future costs of raising a child makes me feel heavily burdened.
5. I worry that parenting will take up a great deal of my time and energy.
6. To spend quality time with my child as they grow up, I may need to cut back on or give up my work or interests.
7. I feel that it would be difficult for me to sustain the emotional attentiveness and patience needed to raise a child over a long period.
8. The thought of the substantial, sustained effort required to raise a child (e.g., attending to their education and development) makes me feel stressed.

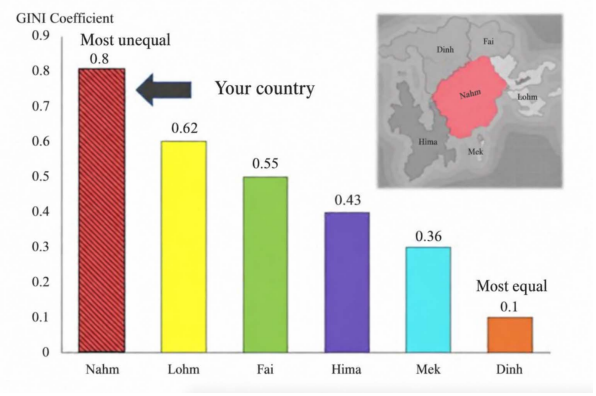
Study 4A Economic Inequality Priming Materials

[High Economic Inequality Condition]

For certain reasons, you have immigrated to Nahm. Nahm is a country with a population of 36 million. It has a rich cultural heritage, a diverse cuisine, and vibrant cultural traditions. Nahm is known for its pleasant weather: most days are cool and breezy, and it rains every year. Most people live in the central region, where the capital, a large city, is located. Travel throughout the country is convenient. Its public transport system is widely regarded as the most convenient in the world, and rail is the main mode of transport. Next, you will learn more about Nahm's economy.

Compared with neighboring countries, Nahm has the highest Gini coefficient, indicating a large gap between rich and poor.

The balance below represents the distribution of wealth in Nahm. The pans at its two ends represent the wealth owned by the richest and poorest 5% of the population, respectively. As you can see, the balance is highly uneven, indicating a large disparity in wealth distribution in this society. This situation has persisted for decades. Your household's current economic status is in the middle of this society.



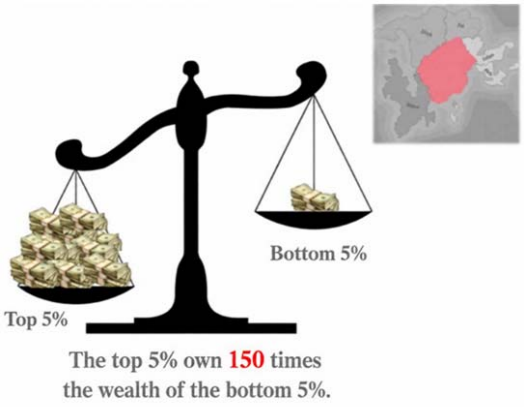
Based on this information, imagine that you live in this society. How would you feel? Please write at least three sentences.

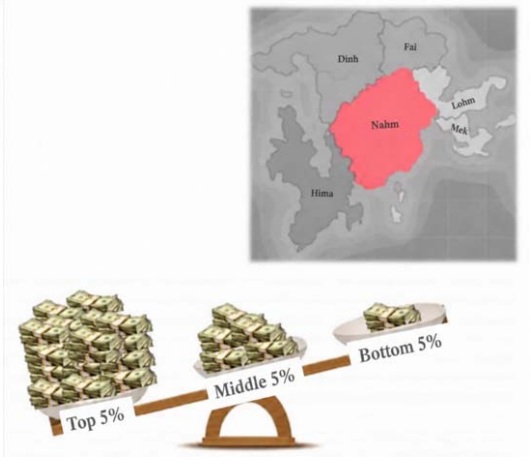
[Low Economic Inequality Condition]

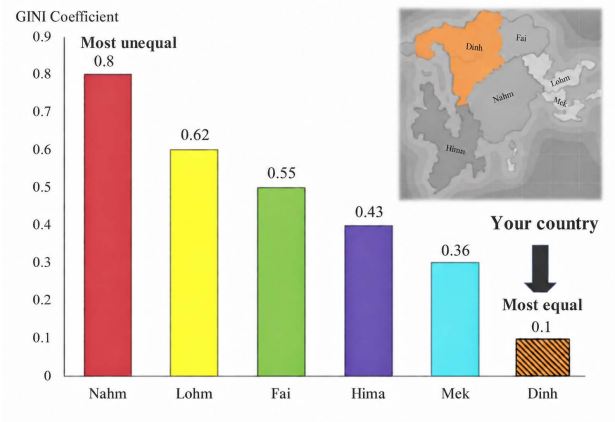
For certain reasons, you have immigrated to Dinh. Dinh is a country with a population of 36 million. It has a rich cultural heritage, a diverse cuisine, and vibrant cultural traditions. Dinh is known for its pleasant weather: most days are cool and breezy, and it rains every year. Most people live in the central region, where the capital, a large city, is located. Travel throughout the country is convenient. Its public transport system is widely regarded as the most convenient in the world, and rail is the main mode of transport. Next, you will learn more about Dinh's economy.

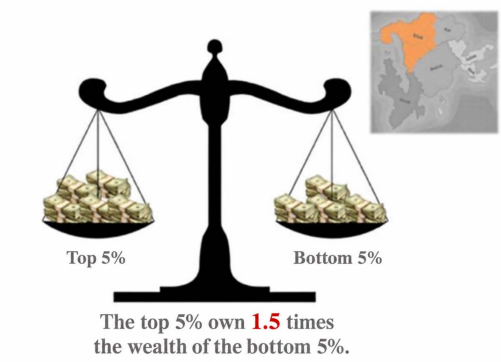
Compared with neighboring countries, Dinh has the lowest Gini coefficient, indicating a small gap between rich and poor.

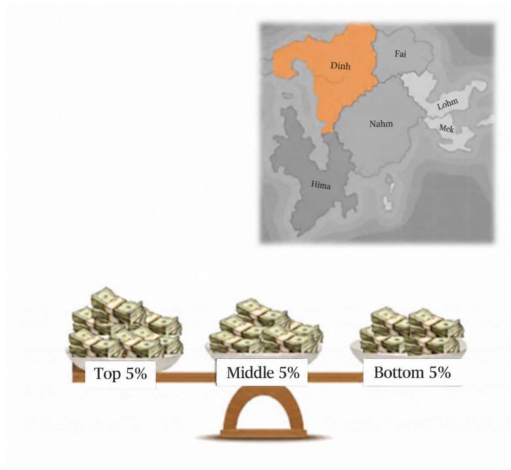
The balance below represents the degree of equality in Dinh. The pans at its two ends represent the wealth owned by the richest and poorest 5% of the population, respectively. As you can see, the balance is relatively even, indicating a small wealth gap in this society. This situation has persisted for decades. Your household's current economic status is in the middle of this society.











Based on this information, imagine that you live in this society. How would you feel? Please write at least three sentences.

[Attention Check]

In the country to which you have immigrated, how many times as much wealth does the top 5% of the population own as the bottom 5%?

○ 1.5 ○ 5 ○ 15 ○ 50 ○ 150

[Economic Inequality Manipulation Check]

1. How large is the wealth gap between different income groups in the country to which you have immigrated? (1 = Very small; 7 = Very large)

2. How unequal is the distribution of wealth in this country? (1 = Very equal; 7 = Very unequal)

Study 4B Economic Inequality Priming Materials

One day, you woke up and suddenly found yourself appear in a new society called “Bimboola”.

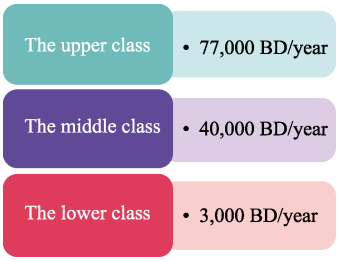
Your age, gender, personality, knowledge and skills did not change. You realized you're going to spend the rest of your life in this society. You were shocked, but you still tried to start a new life.



[High economic inequality condition]

Bimboola is a society that is quite unequal in its wealth distribution. This means that the wealth gap between the poorest and wealthiest people in Bimboola is quite large.

In Bimboola, residents' annual income can be roughly divided into three levels. This income distribution is illustrated in the picture below.



As the figure shows:

• The upper class earns, on average, 77, 000 BD per year

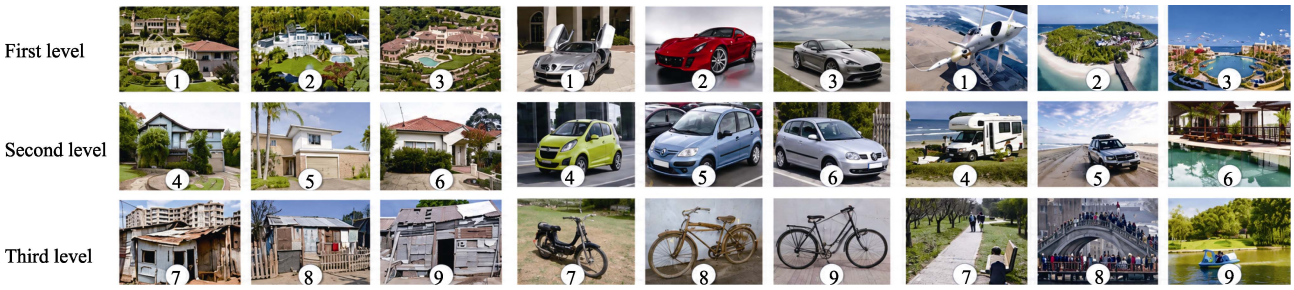
• The middle class earns, on average, 40, 000 BD per year

• The lower class earns, on average, 3, 000 BD per year

Currently, your annual income is 40, 000 BD/year. You belong to the middle class in this society.

To begin your new life in Bimboola, you must purchase daily essentials. The following questions will ask you to select items that you need to live your life in Bimboola.

PLEASE NOTE: As a member of the middle class in this society, you can only select the items that you can afford based on your income group. You are assigned to income group 2, so you can only afford to choose items from the Second level or Third level.



Houses: which one would you choose to purchase?
Transports: which one would you choose to purchase?
Vacations: which one would you choose ?

[Low economic inequality condition]

Bimboola is a society that is quite equal in its wealth distribution. This means that the wealth gap between the poorest and wealthiest people in Bimboola is quite small.

In Bimboola, residents' annual income can be roughly divided into three levels. This income distribution is illustrated in the picture below.

As the figure shows,

• The rich class earns, on average, 50, 000 BD per year
• The middle class earns, on average, 40, 000 BD per year
• The poor class earns, on average, 30, 000 BD per year



Currently, your annual income is 40, 000 BD/year. You belong to the middle class in this society.

To begin your new life in Bimboola, you must purchase daily essentials. The following questions will ask you to select items that you need to live your life in Bimboola.

PLEASE NOTE: As a member of the middle class in this society, you can only choose the items that you can afford based on your income group. You are assigned to income group 2, so you can only afford to select items from the Second level or Third level.

Houses: which one would you choose to purchase?
Transports: which one would you choose to purchase?
Vacations: which one would you choose ?

[Attention Check]

1. In Bimboola, what income level were you assigned to? (1, 2, 3)

[Manipulation Check]

2. In Bimboola, to what extent is the economic distribution unequal?(1 = not at all, 7 = extremely)

3. In Bimboola, to what extent is the economic distribution equal?(1 = not at all, 7 = extremely)

